

DERA SACHA SAUDA EMPIRE OF THE FAITHFULS

In Dera Sacha Sauda, on the outskirts of dusty Sirsa town of Haryana, this is one Baba you cannot miss. He lives in a sprawling seven-acre farmhouse, moves around in swanky suvs with red beacons, sometimes poses riding a motorbike and even plays cricket with kids. The Dera sect chief Baba Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh, 40, who changed his original name to reflect his multi-religion identity, has been the most colourful—and controversial—head of

The Dera has for long tacitly supported different political parties in Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan, where it has a bulk of devotees. But it was only in 2007 that it openly turned pro-Congress. In the Assembly elections in the state held in February, the Dera helped the Congress chalk out an impressive performance in the traditional Akali bastion of Malwa region. The rout in Malwa made SAD dependent on BJP's support to stay in power. The Dera chief cemented his relationship with the Congress by marrying his son with the daughter of a Punjab Congress MLA, Harmohinder Singh Jassi. But Congress's 'religious politics' sowed the seeds of antagonism between the Dera and the ruling SAD, which viewed the sect as a strong political foe.



the sect, which was founded in 1948. To its lakhs of followers, mostly coming from the Dalit and the rural milieu, the Dera is a one-stop station for social service, spiritualism and salvation. The Dera owns a big empire spread over 700 acres, including an air-conditioned market, hospitals, schools, colleges, a hotel and even an amusement park.

But with the CBI probing charges of murder and sexual exploitation against him, the Baba sought protection through politics. He supported the Congress but now may have to pay a heavy price for it.

The sectarian clashes started in Bhatinda on May 14, a day after a local newspaper carried the godman's controversial ad, showing him attired like Guru Gobind Singh and 'baptising' his followers the way the tenth guru had done three centuries ago. For two days, the town was held to ransom by hundreds of irate Sacha Sauda followers, who vented their fury against a motley crowd of Sikh protesters trying to burn Baba's effigy. The administration's laxity in taking preventive action was compounded by a glaring intelligence failure as the authorities had no clue about the sect's sacrilegious ceremony. Worse, the state Government's damage control measures were negligible and as the situation got out of



FURY: A Sikh devotee collars a policeman, (left) Baba's devotees

control, Badal called up Union Home Minister Shivraj Patil to rush 50 companies of paramilitary forces to deal with what top officials called an "explosive situation".

While the sect is sticking to its guns on not offering an apology unless the call for its social boycott and closure of the deras in Punjab is withdrawn, the Sikh clergy is equally adamant. Also, the Badal Government faces a catch-22 situation on Baba's arrest, given that his headquarter is in Haryana.

Already, while the police and paramilitary personnel are guarding the vulnerable deras, fear runs deep among its followers in Punjab. "The Sirsa Dera is inundated with threatening calls and our followers in the countryside are living under fear of attacks," says Arora. In fact, Balwant Singh Nandgarh, *jathedar* of Takht Damdama Sahib, caused a sensation by publicly declaring that Baba's assassin would be weighed against gold. Such rhetoric is only growing shriller by the day. "Only a sagacious approach can cool down the situation," says senior Akali Minister Captain Kanwaljit Singh.

The SAD-BJP Government is worried about the fallout of the sectarian stand-off on the state's agenda for economic revival. "This is the last thing we needed," says state Finance Minister Manpreet Singh Badal. For, at stake is not just the peace, but also investments worth Rs 60,000 crore. The state desperately needs these funds to push up its dismal growth rate of 5 per cent as compared to the national average of 9 per cent. "It's a make or break situation and a long drawn-out crisis may hurt us deeply," says Badal. Clearly, the stakes are too high for Punjab to let the sectarian strife take the state back into gloom.